

THE KEEL

Carina



SIZE RANKING 34

BRIGHTEST STAR
Canopus (α) -0.6

GENITIVE Carinae

ABBREVIATION Car

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
January–AprilFULLY VISIBLE
14°N–90°S

Carina is a major southern constellation that was originally part of the larger figure of Argo Navis, which depicted a ship, until that was split up in the 18th century. Carina represents the ship's keel.

Its most prominent star, Canopus, or Alpha (α) Carinae, is a white supergiant 310 light-years away and second in brightness only to Sirius in the entire sky. The stars Epsilon (ϵ) and Iota (ι) Carinae form a pseudo "southern cross," known as the False Cross, in conjunction with two stars in neighboring Vela.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

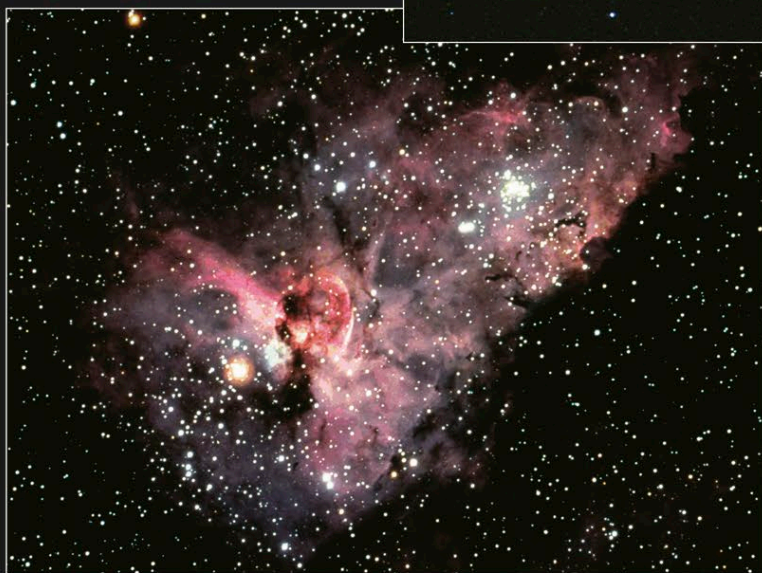
Splashed across the Milky Way near the border with Centaurus and Vela is the Carina Nebula, NGC 3372 (see p.247), a patch of glowing gas four diameters of a full moon wide. It is visible to the eye and well seen through binoculars. The densest and brightest part of the nebula is around Eta (η) Carinae (see p.262), an

ELONGATED CLUSTER

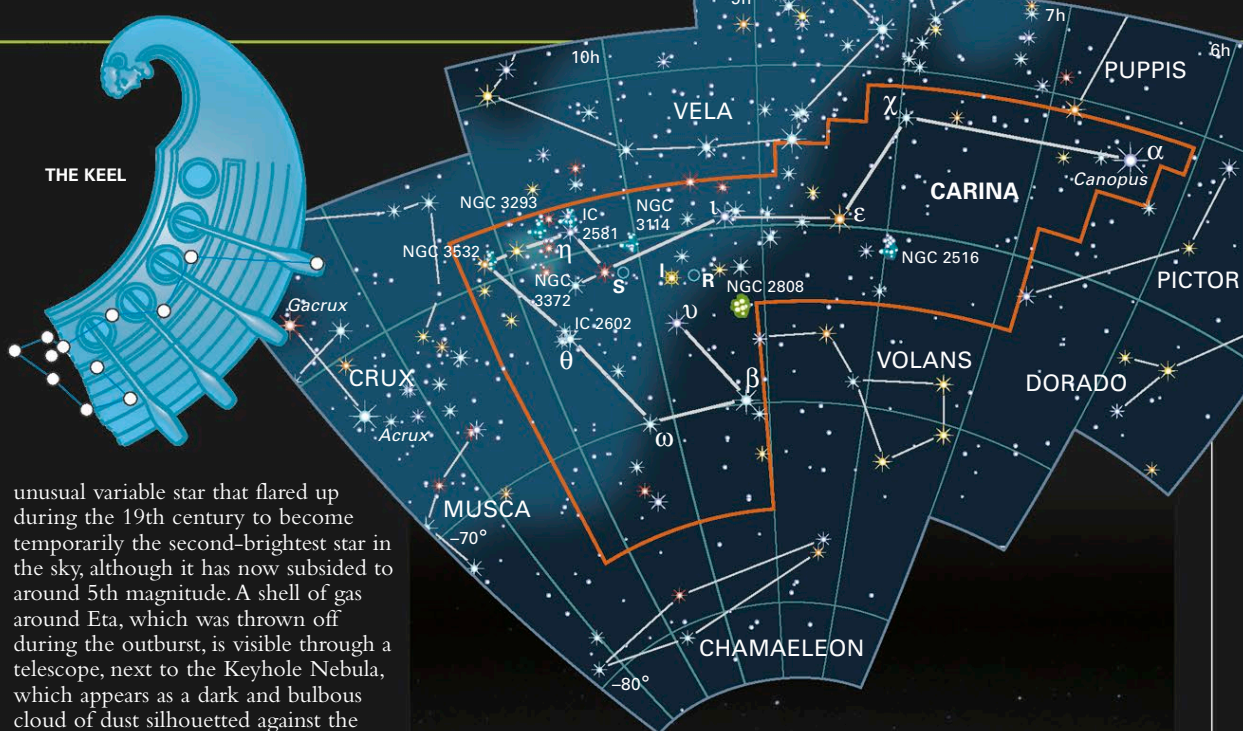
What appears to be the brightest member of NGC 3532, in the lower left of this photograph, is in fact an extremely luminous background star some four times farther off.

THE CARINA NEBULA

The brightest part of this immense cloud of glowing gas is V-shaped (shown here), while the star Eta (η) Carinae itself (below left of center) is a peculiar variable that appears as a hazy orange ellipse.



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unusual variable star that flared up during the 19th century to become temporarily the second-brightest star in the sky, although it has now subsided to around 5th magnitude. A shell of gas around Eta, which was thrown off during the outburst, is visible through a telescope, next to the Keyhole Nebula, which appears as a dark and bulbous cloud of dust silhouetted against the glowing gas of the Carina Nebula.

A glorious sight through binoculars, another treasure is IC 2602, an open cluster known as the Southern Pleiades. Twice the apparent size of a full moon, it contains several stars visible to the naked eye—the brightest being 3rd-magnitude Theta (θ) Carinae.

Among Carina's naked-eye clusters is NGC 3532. At its widest point, this elongated group of stars is twice the width of a full moon. NGC 3114 is about the same apparent size as a full moon, its brightest individual members being visible through binoculars. NGC 2516 is sparser and appears cross-shaped through binoculars. Its brightest star is a 5th-magnitude red giant.



EVEN KEEL

Carina represents the keel and hull of the Argonauts' ship, the *Argo*. The blade of the steering oar is marked by Canopus, Carina's brightest star.